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» RAKESH KUMAR & SHEETAL DEVI

Category: Archery (Mixed Team Compound Open)

Sheetal Devi, the only female armless archer participating in the Paris Paralympics, had a debut Summer Games to remember. She became India's youngest Paralympic medallist, winning bronze in the mixed team compound open archery event. Earlier, she exited the individual competition in the 1/8 elimination round, losing to Tokyo silver medallist Mariana Zuniga by just one point.

Born in 2007 with phocomelia, a rare congenital disorder leading to underdeveloped limbs, Sheetal's arms did not fully form. The Indian Army identified her core strength and ability to use her legs as effectively as one would use their arms. Her archery journey began there.

In 2023, Sheetal became the world record holder in the women's doubles event at the Para World Championships. She also clinched a silver medal at the World Archery Para Championships, becoming the first female armless archer to do so. She ended the year ranked world No. 1 in the women's open category.

The para-archer from Loidhar, a small village in the Kishtwar district of Jammu and Kashmir, gained national attention when her exploits at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games earned her three medals — two golds and a silver.

The nation was captivated by videos from the tournament, showing the young athlete effortlessly lifting the compound bow with her feet, using her mouth to hold the arrow's nock, and consistently hitting the centre of the target board.

Rakesh Kumar, from Katra in Jammu and Kashmir, was born in 1985 to a carpenter and a housewife. An accident in 2010 caused paralysis in both legs, leaving him permanently wheelchair-bound.

The challenges of life nearly drove him to suicide, but Rakesh found hope when sport entered his life.

In 2017, when an archery centre was established at the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board Sports Complex, he was introduced to archery during a demonstration and has stuck with it ever since.

At the Tokyo Paralympics, Rakesh finished sixth in the individual event. Alongside consistent national-level success, he won gold at the Asian Para Games in the mixed team event with Sheetal, as well as silver medals in the individual and men's team compound events. In 2023, he claimed gold in the mixed team event at the World Para Archery Championships and secured a golden double at the Asian Championships.

Compiled by Netra V, Saikat Chakraborty, Anish Pathiyil, Nihit Sachdeva, Kavita Menon & Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan